THE POWER OF TWO

Key factors in the JMM's win

SYMPATHY WAVE

- Hemant Soren leveraged the sympathy generated by his arrest in January and five months in jail to gain trust of tribal voters

KALPANA STEPS UP

- Kalpana Soren addressed over 100 public meetings, forged a connect with women

WOMEN VOTERS

- The Maiya Samman Yojana, launched in August, provides Rs 1,000 a month—to be hiked to Rs 2,500— to over 5 million women. In 68 of 81 constituencies, women voters outnumbered men—a significant majority favour the INDIA bloc

COUNTER-PRODUCTIVE BJP TACTICS

- BJP's allegations linking the Sorens with "Bangladeshi infiltrators" backfired, strengthened sympathy wave for Sorens
- Its attempts to fracture JMM's tribal-Muslim coalition (comprising 41% of the population) by invoking the threat of land-grab through infiltration rejected by voters

TRIBAL TRIUMPH

- By securing 27 out of 28 reserved tribal seats, the INDIA coalition showcased its robust grassroots strategy and widespread voter appeal

DIVISION OF MAHTO VOTERS

- Split in voting preferences of the numerically significant Mahto community, who are traditional NDA supporters, with the entry of Jharkhand Loktantrik Krantikari Morcha (JLKM)



ANI

WINNING TEAM Hemant Soren with wife Kalpana

tration in the Santhal Parganas. Senior leaders, including Amit Shah, amplified this, framing it as a grave threat to tribal identity. BJP leaders branded it as "love and land jihad", alleging that "infiltrators" were marrying tribal women to seize their assets. Despite having substantive issues to address—poverty, unemployment and their dismal corollary, outmigration, besides corruption—the BJP favoured a fear-driven narrative. It was resoundingly rejected by voters.

Tribals and Muslims (14.5 per cent of the population) account for nearly 41 per cent of the electorate, who typically lean towards the JMM. The CSDS survey shows 90 per cent of Muslims, 72 per cent of Oraon, 60 per cent of Munda and 42 per cent Santhal voters went with the INDIA bloc. The NDA's consolation was backing from 48 per cent of Santhal voters.

There was another piece in the jigsaw that went missing: the numerically significant OBC Mahto community which usually backs the NDA. With the emergence of Jairam Mahto's Jharkhand Loktantrik Krantikari Morcha (JLKM), this vote was fragmented. While Jairam was the sole winner, JLKM candidates siphoned off enough votes to hurt the NDA. In at least 15 seats where the NDA lost, the JLKM's vote share exceeded the margin of defeat, underscoring its disruptive impact.

BJP state president Marandi has shown no inclination towards a course correction after the setback. Even after the results, he was heard saying: "Bangladeshi infiltration is not merely an election issue. It is a question of...the future of the tribal community." Some BJP leaders admit Marandi's reinduction had failed as a strategy. At 69, Jharkhand's first CM has struggled to broaden the party's appeal. Murmurs are growing within BJP ranks about the need for a leadership change. As internal discontent simmers, the BJP's direction in Jharkhand is uncertain.

Challenges for the CM

On November 26, he and Kalpana travelled to New Delhi and met Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and party stars Rahul and Priyanka Gandhi. The couple also paid a visit to Prime Minister Narendra Modi. With the election behind them, the Sorens are keen to put the acrimonious campaign behind.

Actually, Soren might need a helping hand from the Centre. He faces a daunting financial challenge. Soren has reiterated his demand that the Centre release Rs 1.36 lakh crore, which he claims is owed to Jharkhand for unpaid coal royalties, compensation for land acquisition and interest on delayed payments. The Maiya Samman scheme alone is expected to cost the state exchequer Rs 15,000 crore every year. There are other expensive promises to keep—giving LPG cylinders to households at Rs 450 and hiking minimum support prices of paddy to Rs 3,200 a quintal. Other pledges include hiking reservation for STs, SCs and OBCs and generating a million jobs. "I am not asking for special status or a special budget," Soren, who was sworn in as CM on November 28, has previously stated. "We only want what is rightfully ours." A battle of a different kind awaits him. ■